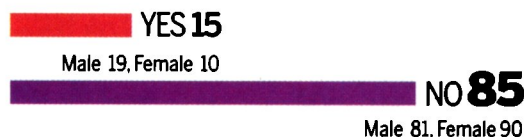


The idea of fetish has an interesting lineage. It is both a product of European engagements with 'primitive' cultures that existed beyond Europe's borders, as well as 'irrational' thinking that, apparently, proliferated within them. In the former case, early 17th century explorers, traders, sailors and others brought back fabulous tales of curious objects that were regarded by Africans as having divine and magical powers. The age of European plunder of African territories had not yet begun, but tales of African 'irrationality' and child-like behaviour—that were later to form crucial aspects of the justification for colonialism—had started to take form. Certain African objects of veneration, charms and talismans, subsequently came to be known as fetishes, a term of Portuguese origin that has connotations of the artificial and the made-up. The career of fetish took a dramatically different turn in the writings of Karl Marx whose idea of commodity fetishism sought to expose the irrationality of capitalist thought that imbued commodities and money with a life of their own, failing to see that they were produced through relations that existed between the labouring and capital-owning classes. What Marx meant to say was that for all their claims to rationality, Europeans could also be primitive in their thinking. Additionally, what he ended up implying was that African primitivism was, indeed, an inferior type of thinking.

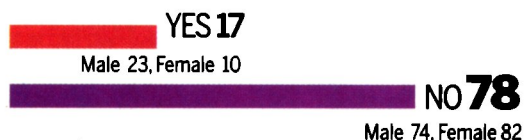
Through the writings of a long list of European sexologists—the best known among them was Havelock Ellis (1859-1939)—fetishes came to be associated with behaviour where objects (a pair of gloves, for example), or parts of the body (the foot, say) that apparently had no sexual nature, could take on erotic significance. Significantly enough, fetishistic behaviour came to be discussed through the following terms: deviancy, irrationality, psychopathic, weak sexuality, disorder and degeneration. The fetish and the fetishist were soon to become objects of a vast array of therapeutic procedures: a colonialism of a different kind, you might say. Given this history of the fetish, frequently regarded as a 'dark continent' of the human psyche, the sex survey for 2009 might provoke us to think about possible changes in what is regarded as perverse and irrational. Before discussing the survey itself, however, there are two aspects to remember. First, surveys can be a slippery tool of

Have you ever tried role playing while having sex?



For 4,222 respondents of the total 5,371 who have had sex. All figures in per cent.

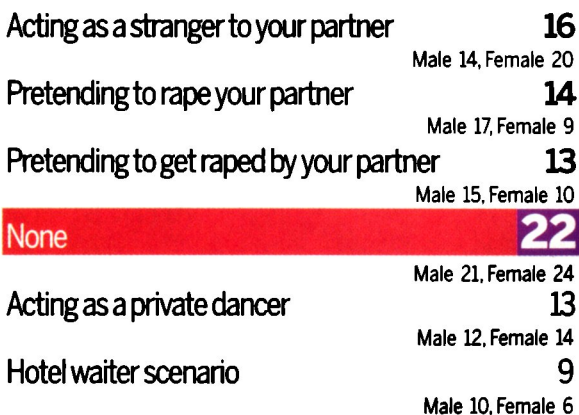
Have you ever fantasised about indulging in role playing?



Rest don't know/can't say. All figures in per cent.

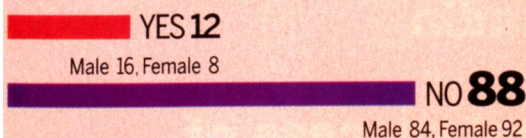
Though an equal number of men and women in Mumbai (33 per cent) fantasise about role playing, nearly three out of 10 Mumbaikars have admitted to enacting them.

What kind of role play have you tried with your partner?



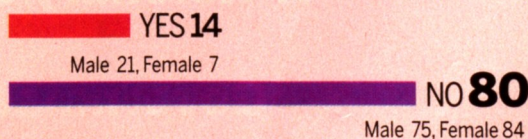
For 630 respondents of the total 5,371 who have indulged in role playing. Figures don't add up to 100 because of multiple choices. All figures in per cent.

Have you ever tried bondage sex?



For 4,222 respondents of the total 5,371 who have had sex. All figures in per cent.

Would you like to try bondage sex?



Rest don't know/can't say. All figures in per cent.

While Kolkata tops the chart with 51 per cent admitting to having tried sado-masochistic sex, 20 per cent men and 9 per cent women in the age group of 35-40 have tried it.